

MOVING ON WITH MY LIFE

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Normalize the experience of grief.
2. Learn that grief can be addressed and resolved in a number of ways.
3. Resolve feelings of anger, sadness, guilt, and/or abandonment surrounding a loss and make plans for the future.
4. Accept a loss and increase social contact with others.
5. Develop a plan for life, renewing old relationships and forming new ones.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE UNRESOLVED GRIEF OR LOSS

- Am I Having Difficulty Letting Go?
- Building My Support Network
- Coping with Addiction and Mood Disorders or Bereavement
- Handling Crisis
- Identifying and Using Community Resources
- Learning to Self-Soothe
- Safe and Peaceful Place Meditation
- Understanding Spirituality
- Using My Support Network

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Childhood Trauma
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Moving on with My Life” activity is suited for clients who are experiencing loss or losses. It offers suggestions for action toward resolving grief and loss. Grief over a particular loss can be new or old. This activity asks the client to take an active role in determining how he/she will continue living his/her life and regain as much quality of life as possible in spite of the loss. It can be helpful to pro-

cess family and cultural issues and identify barriers and resources specific to the client's situation. This exercise may be useful for skills training in individual and/or group settings—that is, the therapist would teach a skill in session—then have the client or group practice the new skill as homework for a set length of time, and report the outcomes at a future session.

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A host of feelings and thoughts may be attached to loss. Grief is a normal and natural reaction to losing someone or something important. Depending on how meaningful a loss is, the feelings related to it may vary from mild to very intense, and may be easy or difficult to resolve. Unresolved grief can keep us from participating in our own day-to-day lives. Part of recovery is learning to manage our feelings, both pleasant and painful, with positive skills and without addictive behaviors. Until we are willing to resolve any loss, it can remain a trigger for relapse. It is important to remember that recovery is about action, and just waiting for time to pass will not heal what's unresolved. Further, to recover from loss, we must expect to recover. It does not mean to push ourselves and try to force instant resolution, either; this can be just as dangerous. It is therapeutic and recovery-focused action over time that resolves grief and loss. We aren't taught these skills in school growing up. This exercise gives you a series of suggestions for resolving grief—it will give you alternatives to leaving a loss unresolved, avoiding dealing with it, or staying stuck in grief. It will guide you through steps that others have found useful, so that you can generate your own personal plan for moving on with your life.

Exercises for Grief and Loss

(Caution: If you become overwhelmed during this assignment, stop and take care of yourself first. After you've calmed down, write in a journal about what is causing you difficulty so you can work with your therapist on moving past any especially painful parts of this process.)

1. Please record in a journal or write in letter form all the messages or lessons you have been taught by, or that you've learned from, the loved one who has died or left, or the other person or part of your life that you've lost. This activity helps with feeling abandoned.
2. Give your pain a voice by recording or listing all the ways you feel the pain. This activity helps express and release some of your pain.
3. Write a letter to the person or other part of your life for which you are grieving, telling how you feel about what has happened and the ways in which the loss has affected your life. Be sure to include any questions that remain in your mind about this loss. Second, write a letter back to yourself from the person you are grieving, answering your questions. You may want to do this exercise in two parts and with the help of your therapist. This exercise helps with resolving guilt.

4. Practice the following relaxation strategy of deep breathing to calm stress, sadness, anxiety, and pain: breathe in, counting to 10, breathing from your diaphragm and not your chest (your belly will rise and fall rather than your chest). Exhale, counting to 10. Repeat 10 times. You can visualize yourself doing this in a relaxing setting.
5. Practice visualization to calm yourself. You do this by first practicing item 4 until you feel relaxed. Then picture yourself making whatever positive changes you want to make in your life. Think of who will be in your life, where you will be, and what you will be doing on a daily basis.
6. Surround yourself with understanding and supportive people. Find and join a bereavement support group and/or work with your sponsor. Reconnect with old, positive acquaintances.
7. Write about positive, nourishing memories about your loved one or your previous experience. Grieving doesn't mean forgetting the good stuff.
8. Add a pet or a plant to your environment so you can take care of and nourish life.
9. Lean on spiritual beliefs or philosophies that give you comfort.
10. Remember how you've coped in positive ways with past losses. Write about how you did this and what you can do again now to help you with a loss that remains unresolved.

My Moving On Plan

1. Using suggestions from above or others you have gathered on your own; please make a simple plan for how you will live your life dealing with the losses you have experienced.

2. What suggestions would you make to others who are either beginning to grieve a loss or are avoiding dealing with a loss?

3. What was the hardest part in completing this activity?

4. What questions do you still have? What barriers?

5. Sometimes we have thoughts that nothing can be done to resolve the loss or that we'll never feel better because the loss is too great. We sometimes do this before trying any strategies. Please record any thoughts like this in the space provided so that you can check them out for accuracy with your therapist, a spiritual advisor, and/or someone else who has also experienced a similar loss but seems to be doing better.

Be sure to bring this exercise with you to your next therapy appointment. This may be an exercise that you will have to work on and then rework more than once as you address each loss. Please write about and then discuss with your therapist any problems you encounter and your general feelings about this activity.